The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Gallo Images via Getty Images

Donald Trump gave **Iran** 48 hours to make a deal or open the Strait of Hormuz, after which it would face “all hell”. On March 27th the president said America would start striking civilian energy facilities in ten days. Separately both Iran and America searched for an American pilot whose F-15 warplane was shot down over southern Iran. American forces rescued the plane’s other crew member.

European policymakers are privately pushing back against new **windfall taxes** on big oil, labelling the measures as premature, a source close to the negotiations told the *Economist*. The finance ministers of **Austria**, **Germany**, **Italy**, **Portugal** and **Spain** called for windfall taxes on oil firms amid an energy shock triggered by the war in Iran. In a letter they urged for “those who profit from the consequences of war” to “do their part”. The European Commission is working on “targeted policy measures”, a spokesperson said.

Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, warned that “Radioactive fallout will end life” in the Gulf, after a fourth attack on the area surrounding Iran’s only operational **nuclear power plant** in Bushehr. The plant remained operational following the strikes,

which killed one person, Iran's Atomic Energy Organisation said. Neither America nor Israel has acknowledged the strike.

The Trump administration said it would ask for a significant rise in **defence spending** in its **budget request** to Congress for fiscal 2027. The request includes $1.5trn in military funding, a rise of more than 40% compared with the previous year. The administration said it would partly offset the increase with cuts of $73bn to non-military spending.

Italy's prime minister, **Giorgia Meloni**, met Qatar's Emir, Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, in Doha as part of a two-day diplomatic push to strengthen ties with the Gulf and safeguard Italy's energy supplies. The trip included a stop in Saudi Arabia where Ms Meloni held talks with Mohammed bin Salman, the kingdom's crown prince.

Two **wildfires** that ignited on Friday in southern **California** grew rapidly, prompting evacuation orders. At least two helicopters, 36 fire engines and 260 responders are tackling the blaze. Authorities said windy conditions had contributed to the rapid spread of the fires, which have a combined footprint of around 4,521 acres, more than five times the size of Central Park in New York City.

NASA released images of Earth taken by **astronauts** on board the Orion spacecraft that will fly around the **Moon** as part of the Artemis II mission. The craft is now closer to the Moon than it is to Earth; it is on track to arrive early next week. This crew is the first to leave Earth's orbit since 1972.

Word of the week: "workslop", the unnecessary AI-generated slop that is produced when bosses tell employees they must use the technology. Read Ethan Mollick's guest essay on why employers should treat AI as what it is: weird.

Photograph: Alamy

Britain’s boat race enters new waters

The Oxford and Cambridge Boat Race has not changed much in its 197 years. The decidedly British affair sees university rowers race along the Thames as some 250,000 spectators link the banks. There will be Pimms, picnics and poshos aplenty.

Britons love the familiarity of the fanfare. So some will be unhappy to discover a change to this year’s race, which takes place on Saturday. The BBC has broadcast it almost continuously since 1938 (aside from a stint on ITV between 2005 and 2009). Last year 2.8m people tuned in. But in October Channel 4 won the television rights; the BBC lost the radio rights earlier this year, too.

Critics see that as evidence that the public-service broadcaster is losing its way, neglecting beloved British traditions for more contemporary programming, such as game shows. Some may conclude that the boat crews are not the only ones in danger of being left behind.

Photograph: Getty Images

Vietnam’s leader tightens his grip on power

Vietnam’s leaders will gather this weekend ahead of the country’s National Assembly on Monday. Top of the agenda will be the election of new national leaders. To Lam, the chief of the Communist Party, is widely expected to be named president. That would mark a break with precedent: unlike in China, Vietnam has traditionally kept the leadership of party and state separate.

Mr Lam, a former policeman, became general secretary after his predecessor died in 2024. Since then he has pushed through sweeping bureaucratic reforms, cutting the number of provinces and shedding tens of thousands of state employees. In January he won out in a factional battle with the army to secure a full five-year term as the party’s general secretary. Taking on the presidency would further concentrate power in his hands, moving Vietnam away from its traditionally more collective style of leadership—and closer to the model seen in China.

Photograph: Dasarath Deka/ZUMA/eyevine

Iran war looms over India’s state elections

Narendra Modi, India’s prime minister, will visit Kerala this weekend to campaign ahead of state elections next Thursday. The contest is set to challenge the truism that “all politics is local”. In Assam and Puducherry, campaigns still revolve around familiar domestic concerns.

In Kerala, however, the war with Iran looms large. Around 80% of the state’s more than 2m emigrants live in the Gulf, and the region accounts for roughly 40% of India’s remittances. That leaves Keralites unusually exposed to the conflict’s risks. The incumbent communist-led government has criticised Mr Modi’s reluctance to publicly condemn the Western-led attacks, tapping into the state’s long-standing anti-imperialist sentiment.

The prime minister’s Bharatiya Janata Party is also trying to turn the crisis to its advantage. It points to the evacuation of tens of thousands of Indian citizens and Mr Modi’s ties with Gulf monarchs, betting that, in a crisis, voters will prioritise safety and effective diplomacy over ideological opposition to the war.

Photograph: Alamy

Weekend profile: Mohamed Bagher Qalibaf, Iran’s potential dealmaker

For decades, Mohamed Bagher Qalibaf has tried to make himself the people’s choice. Over more than 20 years he has run for president repeatedly and each time voters have chosen someone else. What the ballot box denied him, however, war may yet supply. A wave of Israeli assassinations has thinned Iran’s senior ranks, placing the wily 64-year-old at the centre of decision-making.

Among the regime’s ageing elite, Mr Qalibaf stands out. A product of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), he has often leaned towards pragmatism: diplomacy over confrontation, deals over dogma. When Donald Trump mused about new Iranian interlocutors willing to negotiate, he may have had figures like Mr Qalibaf in mind.

His military credentials are formidable. He fought in the Iran–Iraq war of the 1980s, forging ties with commanders who remain influential. A rapid riser, he was appointed head of the IRGC’s air force in his mid-30s. On a recent visit to Beirut to meet Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militant group, he reportedly piloted his own aircraft. When the Islamic Republic shifted from war to reconstruction in the 1990s, he pivoted to politics. He served for 12 years as mayor of Tehran, the capital, and, since 2020, as speaker of parliament.

He has never been especially popular. He once boasted of charging anti-regime protesters on a motorbike, a remark that has stuck. But he has long enjoyed the backing of powerful insiders, including Mojtaba Khamenei, the new supreme leader (and son of the last one), and Hossein Taeb, a former intelligence chief.

That backing has not shielded him from criticism among regime insiders. Hardliners accuse him of profiteering. As mayor, he was linked to the transfer of valuable public land to Guard-related entities and to a charity run by his wife. Social media has amplified stories of family wealth, including a failed attempt by his son to secure a Canadian passport.

For ideologues who cast the Islamic Republic as a champion of the poor, such tales jar. Yet those same traits that made him unpopular —pragmatism, connections and a tolerance for dealmaking—may now work in his favour.

For the moment, Mr Qalibaf is keeping a low profile. The bombastic video messages he posted early in the conflict have given way to terse social-media posts. Some speculate that he is injured or dead. Younger hardliners are gaining ground, and Israel has shown a readiness to target potential dealmakers. In war, as in politics, his moment may yet slip away.

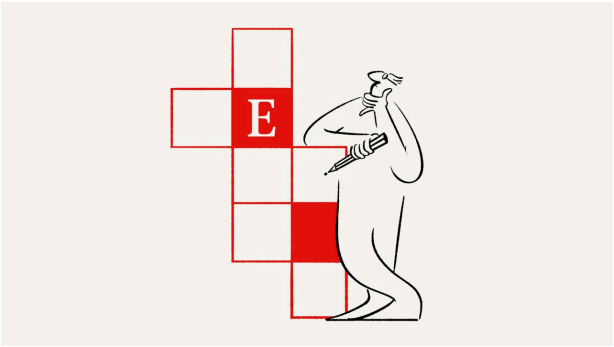

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - One who rests makes tracks (7)

2 across - Too many don’t go back to find ball of energy (6)

3 across - Statesman’s frightful treason (7)

1 down - No! SOS! Children throw up what they have to eat between lessons (6,7)

Straight clues

1 across - Something that achieves delayed success (7)

2 across - Changes movement into electricity (6)

3 across - Schumer, for example (7)

4 down - Institutional meals (6,7)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Nancy Dixon, Kansas City, Missouri, America
Iskriyana Vasileva, Berlin, Germany
Dervla Batt, Dublin, Ireland

They gave the correct answers of John Stennis, George H.W. Bush, Harry Truman, Chester Nimitz and Gerald Ford. The theme is that they all have current US aircraft carriers named after them.

The questions were

Monday: Richard Nixon proposed which long-running Mississippi Senator, who suffered from poor hearing, as an intermediary who should listen to the Watergate tapes and summarise them for investigators?

Tuesday: Who served as both America's ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Thursday: Which Admiral was selected to be commander of the US Pacific fleet in the wake of the Pearl Harbour attacks?

Friday: Which American president pardoned Richard Nixon?

Hell is truth seen too late.

Thomas Hobbes